

New York University Shanghai

Country report Switzerland

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SOCS-SHU 170: Introduction to Global Health

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Abstract

Switzerland is known as the Federal Republic of Switzerland. This report will examine and present a comprehensive country overview of Switzerland from six latitudes, including geographic and socioeconomic status, demographic profile, major public health challenges, epidemiologic profile, and health infrastructure and systems. The study finds that Switzerland also has many limitations and challenges.

1. Geographic

Switzerland's WHO Region: European Region. According to the Federal Department of Foreign Affairs (FDFA), Switzerland is located in the center of Europe. With an area of 41,285 square kilometers, it can be divided into three distinct regions: the Alps account for about 58 percent of the country, the Central Plateau for about 31 percent, and the Jura for 11 percent. Approximately 70% of Switzerland is, therefore, mountainous. However, "only a quarter of the population lives in those regions" (FDFA). The Central Plateau region is, therefore, densely populated.

At the same time, Switzerland is a land of water. According to the FDFA, Switzerland has about 1,500 lakes, which, together with other bodies of water such as streams and lakes, account for 4% of the country's surface area. The headwaters of Switzerland's four major rivers (Rhine, Rhone, Reuss, and Ticino) are located in the Gotha massif in the heart of the Swiss Alps. In addition to the rivers, "Glaciers cover approximately 1,000 km² of Switzerland's territory." However, "between 1985 and 2009, they shrank by as much as 3,000 km² of Switzerland's territory. However, "between 1985 and 2009, they shrank by as much as 390 km²" (FDFA).

Switzerland's glacier decline is mainly due to climate change. According to data from the World Bank, Switzerland's average surface temperature is increasing every year from 1901 to 2022. Furthermore, the latest release on the Climate Change website on November 13th, 2023, states that "both Austria and Switzerland are characterized by a clear decrease in mean snow depth (up to -12 cm/ decade on the mean at elevations of -20 cm/year). Decade on the mean at elevations of about 2000 m a.s.l.). Notably, "a combination of low snowfall and soaring temperatures cause unprecedented melting" (CNN). Thus, the combination of higher temperatures and less snowfall in Switzerland is causing glaciers to melt.

Climate change is closely related to human activities. As "due to anthropogenic activities, this natural effect becomes an environmental problem for the entire world. It tends to cause global warming. The world's climate always varied naturally, but climate change largely variates due to the concentration of "greenhouse gases " in the earth's atmosphere since the beginning of time. The world's climate always varied naturally, but climate change largely varies due to the concentration of "greenhouse gases" in the earth's atmosphere since the industrial revolution began" (Samadhi, 86). According to the FDFA, approximately 25% of Swiss GDP is generated by industry. This creates a chain reaction between human activity, climate, and its effects in Switzerland.

2. Socioeconomic situation

Switzerland has the second-highest GDP per capita in the world (USD 86,850 in 2020, according to the IMF). According to the FDFA, about 74% of Switzerland's GDP comes from the service sector and 25% from industry. The agricultural sector

contributes less than 1%.

As a country in the center of Europe, "the EU is Switzerland's main trading partner. Around 66% of Swiss imports come from the EU, and 43% of Swiss exports go to EU countries" (FDFA). It has developed good economic relations with its neighboring countries and uses its geographical advantages.

This small-sized country has small businesses. According to a release in Financing Small and Medium-sized Enterprises and Entrepreneurs 2022, "only 0.8% of all Swiss enterprises are large and SMEs continue to dominate the enterprise landscape, constituting 99.2% of all firms."

3. Demographic profile

According to WHO, the population of Switzerland will be 8,638,613 in 2020.

The population pyramid by age and sex is shown in Figure 1. The Swiss population pyramid reflects a clear trend towards aging. It is characterized by a shrinking base, indicating a decline in the birth rate or a decrease in the proportion of young people. At the same time, the middle and upper parts of the pyramid are markedly elevated, indicating a significant increase in the proportion of older persons and longer life expectancy.

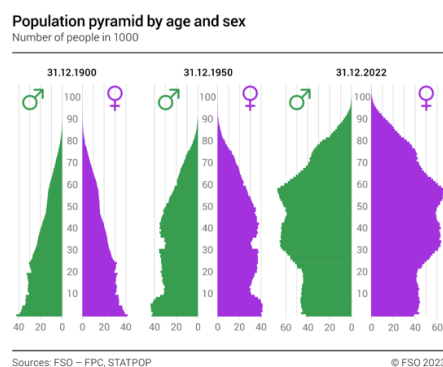


Figure 1, Population pyramid by age and sex

Based on birth and death data from the FDFA, in 2022, Switzerland will have a mortality rate of 8.5 and a crude birth rate of 9.4, reflecting a demographic structure in which the number of deaths per 1,000 population is slightly higher than the number of births. The interplay between mortality and birth rates provides a snapshot of Switzerland's demographic dynamics in that year, with implications for population growth, aging trends, and the overall structure of Swiss society.

In addition to the country's indigenous population, according to the FDFA, "In 2018, 37.5% of the permanent resident population aged 15 and over had a migration background. Just over a third of this population group had Swiss nationality (974,000 people). Four-fifths of the people with a migration background belong to the first generation, while one-fifth was born in Switzerland and is thus part of the second generation." As can be seen from Chart 1, immigrants come mainly from neighboring European countries. This is due to the attraction of Switzerland's unique geographical location and its high level of social security (FDFA, 2018).

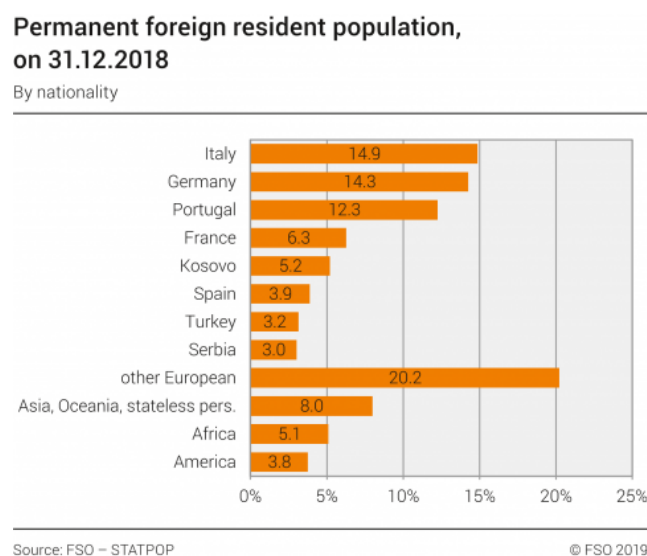


Chart 1, Permanent foreign resident population, on 31.12.2018

4. Major public health challenges

Top 10 causes of death in Switzerland for both sexes aged all ages (2019)

[Hide filters](#) | [Top-10 deaths](#) | [Top-10 DALYs](#) | [Underlying data](#) | [Download with OData API](#)

Filters

Country
Switzerland ▼

Year
2019 ▼

Sex
Both sexes ▼

Age group
All ages ▼

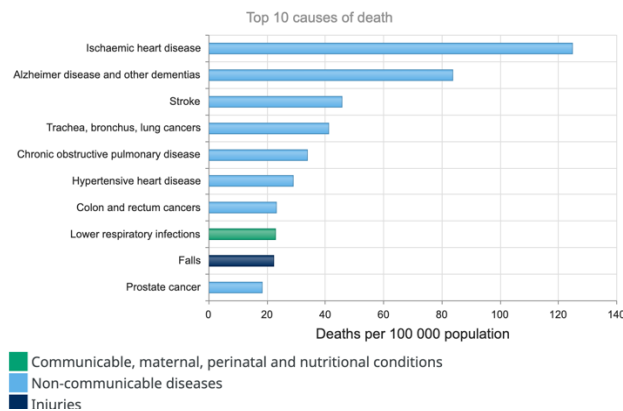


Chart 2, Top 10 causes of death in Switzerland for both sexes aged all ages(2019)

Chart 2 Data from the WHO show that heart disease remains the biggest challenge in Switzerland, which is closely related to the aging population. According to "Switzerland is facing an aging population and a growing amount of patients with chronic diseases" (Claudia, 9).

In contrast, cancer is very diverse but does not constitute a significant challenge. This is due to the medical technology in Switzerland. According to the World Medical Network, Switzerland's Ginnelle Hospital (GSMN) is ranked number one in the world in cancer treatment with a cure rate of 92% (survival for more than 5 years without recurrence).

5. Epidemiological profile

The Swiss Government and the Federal Office of Public Health (FOPH) took decisive action in response to the COVID-19 pandemic. Measures such as social isolation and mask authorization were rapidly implemented.

According to Federal Office of Public Health (FOPH) reports in its subsection on National health strategies, Switzerland has a well-developed health care system that is well able to control both communicable and non-communicable diseases. For common communicable diseases such as influenza and respiratory infections, Switzerland has established efficient surveillance and response mechanisms to ensure that outbreaks are contained. Meanwhile, non-communicable diseases, including cardiovascular problems and cancer, are addressed through a strong health-care infrastructure (FOPH).

Switzerland's efforts in preventive health care are also reflected in its comprehensive vaccination program, which provides immunization against various diseases through routine medical care. Switzerland's proactive stance has made it a leader in the field of public health, addressing pressing issues such as COVID-19 while maintaining a resilient healthcare system to effectively manage health challenges (FOPH) .

6. Health infrastructure and System

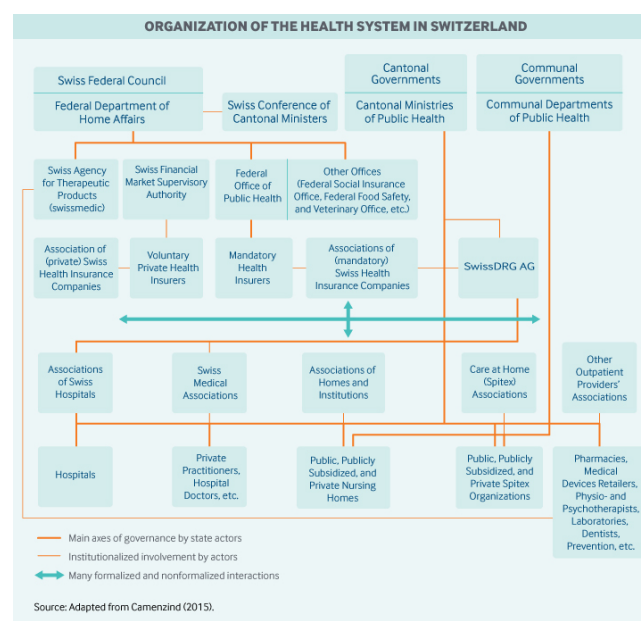


Figure 2 , ORGANIZATION OF THE HEALTH SYSTEM IN SWITZERLAND

Figure 2 explains the organizational framework of the Swiss health care system. In the Swiss healthcare system, the government's roles and responsibilities are decentralized among the federal, cantonal, and municipal levels. The 26 cantons, each with its own constitution, manage duties such as licensing healthcare providers, coordinating hospital services, and supporting health promotion and disease prevention. The federal government oversees system financing, ensures pharmaceutical and medical device quality and safety, manages public health initiatives, and promotes research and training.

Decentralization is prominent, with key governance entities operating at the cantonal level. Elected ministers of public health in each canton, overseen by the Swiss Conference of Cantonal Health Ministers, contribute significantly. The Federal Office of Public Health, a national authority, regulates mandatory health insurance, authorizes premiums, and determines pharmaceutical prices. The Swiss Federal Department of Home Affairs defines insurance benefits with support from the Federal Office of Public Health and Swissmedic, which supervises therapeutic products.

Additionally, the nonprofit SwissDRG AG shapes the national system for determining provider payments, while Health Promotion Switzerland focuses on health promotion programs (Roosa). Patient advocacy involves the Association of Swiss Patients and a national health insurance ombudsman. This multi-tiered structure reflects Switzerland's commitment to effective governance and comprehensive healthcare coverage (Roosa).

Conclusion

This comprehensive overview illuminates the intricacies of Switzerland's diverse landscape, socioeconomic dynamics, demographic shifts, and healthcare system. Despite the country's stunning geography, characterized by mountainous terrains and glacial decline linked to climate change, Switzerland faces pressing challenges, notably an aging population influencing mortality and birth rates. The socioeconomic scene, marked by a strong service sector and high GDP per capita, underscores Switzerland's economic prowess and strategic positioning within Europe. Major public health challenges, notably heart disease and cancer, underscore the impact of an aging demographic on health outcomes. The COVID-19 response exemplifies Switzerland's proactive stance and well-developed healthcare infrastructure in managing communicable and non-communicable diseases. The decentralized health governance structure, involving federal, cantonal, and municipal levels, reflects Switzerland's commitment to effective healthcare management. In navigating these multifaceted aspects, Switzerland stands as a global exemplar in addressing diverse health challenges while maintaining a resilient and accessible healthcare system.

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